

[Return to Search](#)

Ubena of the Rivers

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These three influences, all in their several ways detrimental to the clan system, were probably the main factors in the development of the characteristic group of Bena society, a group which fulfils the economic functions normally associated with the clan and which, for want of any appropriate English term, we must call by a native name—the *mlongo*.

[614](#)
[Clans](#)

A man's *walongo* are all his blood relatives, both maternal and paternal, his and their connections by marriage, those with whom he has sworn blood-brotherhood, and lastly any particular friends on whom he may rely for help in time of need, and who will similarly look to him for aid.† It is a Mutual Service Society. An *mlongo* is described as “one who will feed you ungrudgingly and from whom you can borrow.” He is the friend who is the friend in need. The practical convenience of such a group in aiding the absorption of aliens into tribal life is obvious. Its existence also partly explains the mutual obligations still existing between the families of freed slaves and their former masters.

[476](#)
[Mutual Aid](#)

[571](#)
[Social Relationships And Groups](#)

[572](#)
[Friendships](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

[621](#)
[Community Structure](#)

A man is at home anywhere within the circle of his *walongo*, and consequently destitution, except in times of general shortage, is an unknown phenomenon in Ubena. Within the group a man must play fair, and sharp practice is

[571](#)
[Social Relationships And Groups](#)

definitely regarded as discreditable: without it he may be as crafty as he likes,
and a trick successfully played on an outsider is rather a good joke.

576
Etiquette

† Cf. Kiswahili *ndugu* in its widest sense.

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